

0.0.1 Assemblies

1. There are, O bhikkhus, these two assemblies. Which two? The assembly trained in empty talk, not in counter-questioning, and the assembly trained in counter-questioning, not in empty talk.

2. And which, O bhikkhus, is the assembly trained in empty talk, not in counter-questioning? “Here, O bhikkhus, in this assembly, when the discourses spoken by the Tathagata that are deep, deep in meaning, supramundane, connected with voidness, are being expounded, the bhikkhus do not listen. They do not give ear attentively. They do not apply their minds to understand it. They think those dhammas should not be learned and mastered. However, when discourses spoken by poets, elegant in sound, elegant in phrasing, [composed by] outsiders, spoken by disciples, are being expounded, the bhikkhus do listen. They give ear attentively. They apply their minds to understand it. They think those dhammas should be learned and mastered. They, having mastered that dhamma, do not examine and cross-question each other [asking]: “How is this? What is the meaning of this?” They do not disclose the undisclosed, do not explain the unexplained, and they do not dispel their doubts in regard to the numerous perplexing dhammas. This, O bhikkhus, is called the assembly trained in empty talk, not in counter-questioning.”

3. And which, O bhikkhus, is the assembly trained in counter-questioning, not in empty talk? “Here, O bhikkhus, in this assembly, when discourses spoken by poets, elegant in sound, elegant in phrasing, [composed by] outsiders, spoken by disciples, are being expounded, the bhikkhus do not listen. They do not give ear attentively. They do not apply their minds to understand it. They think those dhammas should not be learned and mastered. However, when the discourses spoken by the Tathagata that are deep, deep in meaning, supramundane, connected with voidness, are being expounded, the bhikkhus do listen. They give ear attentively. They apply their minds to understand it. They think those dhammas should be learned and mastered. They, having mastered that dhamma, do examine and cross-question each other [asking]: “How is this? What is the meaning of this?” They disclose the undisclosed, explain the unexplained, and they dispel their doubts in regard to the numerous perplexing dhammas. This, O bhikkhus, is called the assembly trained in counter-questioning, not in empty talk.”

4. “Of these two assemblies, O bhikkhus, this is the highest, O bhikkhus, namely, the assembly trained in counter-questioning, not in empty talk.”